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california - Democrats delay votes on aid for Trump-related action

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SACRAMENTO >> California legislators on Thursday delayed a vote on a pair of bills that would provide up to $50 million combined for the state Department of Justice and organizations that provide legal services to respond to actions taken by the administration of President Donald Trump.

The Assembly was set to take up the bills after they were approved last week in the Senate. But Democrats were called into a closed door meeting shortly after their work for the day began.

When they emerged roughly an hour later, the measures were not voted on before the body adjourned for the week.

Several lawmakers declined to comment, including Jesse Gabriel, D-San Fernando Valley, who co-authored the bills. On Monday, Gabriel has said he expected the bills to be voted on this week.

Assembly Speaker Robert Rivas, D-Salinas, did not publicly address the decision to not vote on the bills. In a written statement, Rivas spokesperson Nick Miller said: “In the Assembly, we are going to look closely at the special session legal defense bills to ensure they are airtight and protect all Californians.”

The statement said that recent actions by Republicans in Washington, D.C. “jeopardize the programs and services Californians rely on most.”

Earlier this week, the federal Office of Management and Budget caused confusion by issuing a memo that called for a “temporary pause” in most spending across federal agencies. The action was halted in court, and challenged by state Attorney General Rob Bonta, but uncertainty remains about what it could mean for federal funding.

Gov. Gavin Newsom in November ordered the Legislature to convene a special session to prepare for legal challenges and defense against the new administration.

The plan was for the aid to be approved before Jan. 20, when Trump was sworn into office, but that timeline was pushed back after wildfires in the Los Angeles area exploded and the Legislature worked on an aid package in response.

The governor’s Office, in a statement, said Newsom “will take action on these measures when they reach his desk.”

The bills would make available up to $25 million to the Department of Justice “to mitigate the impacts of actions taken by the federal government” and $25 million for grants and contracts to organizations that provide legal services, including for people needing financial help and support on immigration-related cases.

Assembly Republican Leader James Gallagher, R-East Nicolaus, told reporters Thursday that the bills were a “silly stunt that needs to stop.”

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